GEMS OF INDIA

# THE WATER WIZARD

**Dholakia Foundation's lake rejuvenation efforts in arid Amreli have turned around the lives of parched farmers there**

*By* **JUMANA SHAH**



**For as long as anyone can remember,** Amreli district in Gujarat has had a dry arid landscape. In many areas, water is found 600-700 feet below ground level, and with high levels of TDS (total dissolved solids). Migration for work is commonplace in the mostly agrarian community, which is how, in the 1970s, a few enterprising young men ended up in Surat and started in the diamond trade business, eventually setting up polishing units.

A few of these diamantaires developed into billionaire industry leaders. One of the biggest is Hari Krishna Exports, led by Savji Dholakia. In 2008, after the global economic crash, Dholakia returned to his village Dudhala in Lathi taluka of Amreli with a resolve to do some good for his native land. Water shortage, of course, was top of the agenda. The only source was monsoon rainwater that flowed down from the seasonal Gagadiyo river, a tributary of the Shetrunji that flows through the region. That water usually dries up by Diwali (October).

**BENEFICIARYSPEAK**

**"Earlier, with one harvest, we could barely make ends meet. Today, with three, some households earn up to Rs 20 lakh. Groundwater input costs are down 75%"**

**HIMMATBHAI SHANKAR**
*Farmer, Dudhala village*

Dholakia decided to use his company's CSR funds and create a 22-acre pond in the Gagadiyo riverbed, dredging and building check dams to store the monsoon water. They called it the Amrut Sarovar and it was soon a success. "Dudhala was also developed as a model village using the foundation's CSR funds," says Dholakia. The foundation recommended to the state government that they construct similar ponds in every village to store rainwater, as bringing Narmada Dam water to Saurashtra in pipelines through the SAUNI scheme was costing a bomb. But nothing came of it.

For the next eight years, a dozen villages in the region requested